

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Linux

Linux is catching on fast, but perhaps not fast enough. Those of us who are purely Windows or Mac users sometimes get lost when a conversation involves Linux fans. Now you can at least try and hold your own end up in such situations...

BASH: The Bourne-Again Shell is the default shell (command line interface) in most Linux distributions.

Console: When you log into Linux in text mode (command line) from the X Window System, you are said to be in the console.

Daemon: A program that runs actively in the background.

GNOME: The GNU Network Object Model Environment is a Windows-style desktop window manager.

GNU: A recursive acronym, GNU stands for "GNU's Not Unix". It is a project that was launched in 1984 to develop free Unix-like OSes.

GPL: The GNU 'General Public License' is a licensing that requires software coders to make the source code (for programs they create) available freely, in order to qualify for the certification. The Linux kernel and most of the bundled applications in Linux have this license.

KDE: A window manager similar to GNOME.

Man: Short for 'manual', it is the user manual that accompanies most GPL software.

Open Source: Software that distributes its source codes openly, such as all software under the GPL.

Usage: "I reinstalled the Linux kernel the other day. Something happened to GNOME and KDE though, I rebooted and all I got was the BASH prompt! I looked at all the man pages available online, but nothing! Sometimes I feel Open Source isn't all it's cracked up to be!"

So now you know!

Things get a little crazy around 'issue closing'—rather a notorious time—when the magazine goes into print. Readers write in to us all the time and ask how we handle the pressure, deadlines and the knowledge that over 6 lakh readers, at some time in their lives, bet good money on Digit's suggestions. Well, let's take a peek into life during issue closing!

The cast: DA-the don (Deepak Ajwani), AK [47] (Aditya Kubera), Dee Dee (Deepak Dhingra), EDO RAM (Ram Mohan Rao), RoboT (Robert Sovereign-Smith)

DA-the don: What the hell! Everyone forgot about Digit Diary?

EDO RAM: Huh?

Dee Dee: The Test Centre is too busy to write anything more now.

DA-the don: All of you... In my cabin NOW!

AK [47]: *pensive*

RoboT: *doubly

pensive*

EDO RAM: Huh? Wazzat?

Dee Dee: I say we write about the Test Centre! We broke our backs lifting those heavy MFDs!

DA-the don: OK, write it!

Dee Dee: "Arrey, but the Test Centre is too busy to write anything more now."

DA-the don: Who volunteers to write it then?

AK [47]: No way, I'm still piled with proof-reading and last-minute editing!

EDO RAM: Huh? I'm sleepy!

RoboT: Why don't we write what just happened?!

DA-the don: Hmm...why not?

Now you know.

To be honest, there's just been so much work and testing and writing that we have all forgotten about the smaller things. All for you, dear reader... all for you.

DIGIT DIARY

cent had both, Windows PCs and Macs. But of the 36 per cent of respondents who owned digital audio players, more than half owned iPods.

Now, of the respondents who said they had decided to buy a computer in the next 18 months, 7.5 per cent said they were planning on buying a Mac. This won't mean much until you consider the fact that Apple's marketshare in the US is only 3.3 per cent. If all the buying intentions pan out, and the survey is representative of general PC buyers, Apple could conceivably double its marketshare in the not-too-distant future.

As a matter of fact, Apple's revenue and unit shipments of Macs have been growing, and seem to bear suggestions of a halo effect. For some people, the iPod has been their only exposure to Apple products. It appears that that exposure is raising interest in other Apple gear. The survey's bottomline is that overall, only three per cent of people primarily using Windows definitively planned on Mac purchases. However, iPod owners with Windows computers were more than three times as likely to buy a Mac.

SPEEDING UP SEARCHES

Free Plug-In For IE

A free plug-in released July 13 for Internet Explorer allows users to mouse over Web search listings for an instant view of the content, rather than having to wait for the full page to download. The software, created by San Francisco-based Browster, uses patented 'pre-fetching' instant page rendering, which serves up a copy of the Web page in milliseconds in a new window on top of the original search page.

Users can click on links and information in that new window and download data from that Web site. They can exit by moving the mouse back to the main search site or click on an icon in the new window for viewing the previous or next search item in the list of results.

Browster 1.0 works with search sites such as Google and Yahoo, e-commerce sites such as eBay and Amazon, and other Web sites that can be searched for items. The plug-in works with IE 5 and later versions. Other

browsers will be supported in the future, said Browster CEO Scott Milener.

NOTEBOOKS, NOT TEXTBOOKS

Finally, An All-Electronic School

For a few hundred Arizona high school students, it's going to be laptops over textbooks: the Vail Unified School District is gearing up to open the doors of the state's first all-wireless, all-laptop high school. Students will use electronic and online articles as part of lesson plans.

About 350 students at Empire High School will be lent \$850 (Rs 37,000) laptops for the school year, and district officials hope to eventually increase enrolment to 750, according to The Associated Press. A set of textbooks runs about \$500 to \$600 (about Rs 24,000).

While computers in schools are becoming increasingly common, experts say Vail's decision to become an 'e-school' is rare. Cost, insecurity, ignorance and institutional constraints often prevent the switch to